

Sridevi Kapoor (*née* **Shree Amma Yanger Ayyapan**; 13 August 1963 – 24 February 2018), known mononymously as **Sridevi**, was an Indian actress who worked in [Telugu](#), [Tamil](#), [Hindi](#), [Malayalam](#), and [Kannada](#) language films.^{[6][7]} She is regarded as one of the greatest stars of [Indian cinema](#).^{[8][9][10][11]} Cited as the "first female superstar" of [Indian cinema](#),^{[6][7]} she was the recipient of [various accolades](#), including a [National Film Award](#), five [Filmfare Awards](#) (a [Filmfare Lifetime Achievement Award](#), two [Filmfare Awards](#) and two [Filmfare Awards South](#)), two [Tamil Nadu State Film Awards](#), a [Kerala State Film Award](#), and a [Nandi Award](#).^[12] Sridevi's career spanned over 50 years in a wide range of genres. She was known for her reticent and introverted off-screen personality, but headstrong and outspoken on-screen persona, often playing strong-willed women.^{[13][14]} In 2013, Sridevi was honoured with the [Padma Shri](#), the country's fourth highest civilian honour.^[5]

Sridevi made her debut as a child in the 1967 Tamil film *Kandhan Karunai* at the age of four,^[15] and began playing lead roles as a child in [M. A. Thirumugam](#)'s 1969 mythological Tamil film *Thunaivan*. Her first role as an on-screen adult came in 1976 at age 13, in the Tamil film *Moondru Mudichu*. She soon established herself as a leading female star of [South Indian Cinema](#), with roles in such films as *16 Vayathinile* (1977), *Sigappu Rojakkal* (1978), *Padaharella Vayasu* (1978), *Varumayin Niram Sivappu* (1980), *Meendum Kokila* (1981), *Premabhishekam* (1981), *Vazhvey Maayam* (1982), *Moondram Pirai* (1982), *Aakhari Poratam* (1988), *Jagadeka Veerudu Athiloka Sundari* (1990) and *Kshana Kshanam* (1991).

Sridevi's first starring role in [Hindi cinema](#) came with the drama film *Solva Sawan* (1979), and she received wider recognition for the action film *Himmatwala* (1983). She emerged a leading Hindi film star with several successes, including *Mawaali* (1983), *Justice Chaudhury* (1983), *Tohfa* (1984), *Maqsad* (1984), *Masterji* (1985), *Karma* (1986), *Mr. India* (1987), *Waqt Ki Awaz* (1988) and *Chandni* (1989). She received praise for her performances in *Sadma* (1983), *Nagina* (1986), *ChaalBaaz* (1989), *Lamhe* (1991), *Khuda Gawah* (1992), *Gumrah* (1993), *Laadla* (1994), and *Judaai* (1997). Following a hiatus, she played the title role in the television sitcom *Malini Iyer* (2004–2005). Sridevi returned to film acting with the comedy-drama *English Vinglish* (2012) and had her 300th and final film role in the crime thriller *Mom* (2017). She earned acclaim for both performances, and for the latter was posthumously awarded the [National Film Award for Best Actress](#).

On 24 February 2018, she was found dead in her guest room at the [Jumeirah Emirates Towers Hotel](#) in [Dubai](#), [United Arab Emirates](#), with the cause cited as accidental drowning.^[16] News of her death featured prominently in Indian and international media. She was married to film producer [Boney Kapoor](#), with whom she had two daughters, actresses [Janhvi](#) and [Khushi Kapoor](#).

Life and career

1963–1975: Early years and work

Sridevi was born as Shree Amma Yanger Ayyapan^{[17][18]} on 13 August 1963 in [Meenampatti](#) village^[19] near [Sivakasi](#), [Tamil Nadu](#), India^[20] to Ayyapan and Rajeswari.^{[21][22][23]} Her father was a lawyer from Sivakasi while her mother was from [Tirupati](#), [Andhra Pradesh](#).^{[24][25][26]} Sridevi's mother tongue was [Telugu](#), and she was fluent in Tamil.^{[27][28]} She has a sister and two step-brothers.^[29]

"I lost out on going to school and college life, but I got into the film industry and worked without a gap – from child actor, I went straight to heroine. There was no time to think and I was grateful for it.

—Sridevi, *The New Indian Express*, 2013^[30]

Sridevi started her career as a child actor at the age of four in the Tamil movie [Kandhan Karunai](#) in 1967.^[31] Subsequently, she played the role of young [Muruga](#) in [Thunaivan](#), which was her first breakthrough as child artist.^[32] Actress [Sowcar Janaki](#) opined that her "sharp features, sparkling eyes and innocent smile would be more than a handful for the role."^[33] Sridevi made her debut in [Telugu cinema](#) as a child artist with the 1970 film *Maa Nanna Nirdoshi*.^[citation needed] Baby Sridevi's performance in [Poompatta](#) (1971) in Malayalam won her the [Kerala State Film Award for Best Child Artist](#).^[34] [Kandhan Karunai](#) (1967), [Nam Naadu](#) (1969), [Prarthanai](#) (1970), [Babu](#) (1971), [Badi Panthulu](#) (1972), [Bala Bharatam](#) (1972), [Vasantha Maaligai](#) (1972) and [Bhakta Kumbara](#) (1974) are the most notable films of her career as a child artist.^[34] In 1972, Sridevi debuted as a child artist in [Bollywood](#) with [Rani Mera Naam](#) directed by [K. S. R. Das](#).^[35] She also appeared in the film [Julie](#), where she played the younger sister to the protagonist [Lakshmi](#).^[34] She acted with [Jayalalithaa](#) in [Thirumangalyam](#), [Kandan Karunai](#) and [Adi Parashakti](#).^[36]

1976–1982: Success in South India

Sridevi's lead roles in [Telugu](#) include [Padaharella Vayasu](#), [Konda Veeti Simham](#), [Vetagaadu](#), [Sardar Paparayudu](#) and [Bobbili Puli](#).^[37] With [Akkineni Nageswara Rao](#), she appeared in movies such as [Premabhishekham](#), [Bangaru Kanuka](#) and [Prema Kanuka](#) as well as with [Krishna](#) in [Kalavari Samsaram](#), [Adavi Simhalu](#), [Gharana Donga](#), [Kirayi Kotigadu](#), [Pachani Kapuram](#), and [Ram Robert Rahim](#).^[37] She acted with [Chiranjeevi](#) in [Jagadeka Veerudu Athiloka Sundari](#), [S. P. Parasuram](#).^[37] She acted with [Nagarjuna](#) in [Aakhari Poratam](#) (1988), and [Govinda Govinda](#) (1993). Her performance in the 1992 [Ram Gopal Varma](#) directed [Kshana Kshanam](#) won her the [Filmfare Award for Best Actress – Telugu](#) and the [Nandi Award for Best Actress](#).^[38] Sridevi has acted in a total of 95 Telugu language films.

In 1976, Sridevi landed her first leading role in the Tamil film *Moondru Mudichu* directed by K. Balachander.^[39] She followed it with a number of films with Kamal Haasan and Rajinikanth. Sridevi's first release of 1977 was *Gaayathri*, followed by *Kavikkuyil* and *16 Vayathinile*, where she played the role of a young girl who is caught between her 2 lovers.^[40] She also starred in the film's Telugu remake *Padaharella Vayasu* in 1978.^[37] Her subsequent notable films included Bharathi Raja's *Sigappu Rojakkal*, S. P. Muthuraman's *Priya*, *Karthika Deepam*, *Johnny*, *Varumayin Niram Sivappu* and *Aakali Rajyam*.^[41] She acted with N. T. Rama Rao in *Vetagaadu*, *Sardar Papa Rayudu*, *Bobbili Puli*, *Justice Chowdhary* and *Aatagadu*.^[37] She acted alongside Sivaji Ganesan in *Sandhippu*, *Kavari Maan* and the Sri Lanka-filmed coproduction *Pilot Premnath*.^[42]

Sridevi debuted as child artist in Kannada with *Bhakta Kumbara* (1974) directed by Hunsur Krishnamurthy.^[43] Her other films as a child artist in Kannada included *Bala Bharatam* and *Yashoda Krishna*.^[43] She was also a part of *Hennu Samsarada Kannu* (1975), directed by A. V. Seshagiri Rao. Sridevi also acted as lead opposite Ambareesh in *Priya* (1978), produced by S. P. Muthuraman.^[43] She entered Malayalam films as a child actor with *Kumara Sambhavam* in 1969,^[44] followed by I. V. Sasi's *Abhinandanam*. Her notable Malayalam films as the lead heroine were *Thulavarsham*, directed by N. Sankaran Nair in 1976, and M. Masthan's *Kuttavum Shikshayum*, a remake of the Tamil film *Pennai Nambungal* with Kamal Haasan starring opposite her.^[45]

She next appeared in the Malayalam releases like *Aa Nimisham*, *Angeekaaram* and *Satyavan Savithri* directed by P.G. Viswambharan.^[45] In 1981, she starred in the Tamil film *Meendum Kokila* which won her the *Filmfare Award for Best Actress – Tamil*.^[46] In 1982, Sridevi starred in *Moondram Pirai* playing a woman suffering from *retrograde amnesia* and went on to win the *Tamil Nadu State Film Award for Best Actress*.^[47] She was paired with Kamal Haasan in 27 films across languages.^[48]

1983–1986: Hindi film debut and success

Sridevi made her debut as a heroine in Hindi films in *Solva Sawan* in 1979.^[49] 4 years later, she was signed to star opposite Jeetendra in *Himmatwala* (remake of Telugu film *Ooruki Monagadu* (1981)). The film released in 1983, and was one of the highest-grossing Hindi films of the year.^[50] It established Sridevi in Bollywood.^[citation needed] Her dance number "Nainon Mein Sapna" became a rage with *Rediff* stating that "the water pots may have dominated most frames in 'Nainon Mein Sapna', but it was Sridevi's bejewelled outfits and headgears that stole the show".^[51] She followed with *Tohfa*, which was the highest-grossing Hindi film of 1984.^[52] The film established Sridevi as one of the leading actresses of Bollywood,^[53] with *Filmfare* magazine declaring her "Unquestionably #1" on their cover.^[54]

The pair of Jeetendra-Sridevi did 16 films together of which *Himmatwala* (1983), *Jaani Dost* (1983), *Justice Chaudhry* (1983), *Mawaali* (1983), *Akalmand* (1984), *Tohfa* (1984), *Balidaan* (1985), *Aulad* (1987), *Suhaagan* (1986), *Ghar Sansar* (1986), *Dharm Adhikari* (1986), *Sone Pe Suhaaga* (1988) were successful, and *Aag Aur Shola* (1986), *Himmat Aur Mehanat* (1987), *Sarfaroosh* (1985) were flops.^{[55][56]}

However, it was *Sadma* (1983) which brought Sridevi widespread critical acclaim.^[citation needed] A remake of her Tamil film *Moondram Pirai*, *Sadma* is included in *iDiva*'s list of '10 Must Watch Movies That Weren't Blockbusters'.^[57] Sridevi's performance as a child-woman suffering from amnesia was called by *Indian Express* "a milestone in her illustrious career".^[58] Sridevi also featured in the *Mid-Day*'s list of 'Challenging Roles played by Bollywood Actors' describing her act in the film as "her best performance ever".^[59] In 2012, *Adil Hussain*, Sridevi's co-star in *English Vinglish* revealed that he became a fan of the actress after watching her in *Sadma*.^[60] The Sridevi-Kamal Hassan pair also appeared on the *CNN-IBN* 2012 list of 'Greatest Romantic Couples on Celluloid'.^[61] The film earned Sridevi her first *Filmfare* nomination for *Best Actress*.

Sridevi had successful pairing with *Rajesh Khanna* in films such as *Naya Kadam* (1984), *Maqсад* (1984), *Masterji* (1985) and *Nazrana* (1987). In 1986, came the snake fantasy *Nagina* which saw Sridevi play a *shape-shifting* woman. The film turned out to be the second highest-grossing film of the year,^[62] with *Box Office India* stating that Sridevi remained "the undisputed #1".^[53] It was also named one of the best snake fantasy films by *Yahoo*.^[63] *Times of India* ranked *Nagina* as one of the 'Top 10 Snake Films of Hindi Cinema'.^[64] Sridevi's climax dance number "Main Teri Dushman" also remains one of the best snake dances in Bollywood,^[65] with *Desi Hits* calling it "one of Sridevi's most iconic dance numbers... that still gives fans goose bumps"^[66] and *iDiva* describing it as "the stuff of movie legends".^[67] *Nagina* is credited as being the film which established Sridevi's position as the biggest female star of the 1980s, rivalling male stars like *Amitabh Bachchan* and *Dharmendra*. Besides *Nagina*, 1986 also saw Sridevi giving box-office hits in *Subhash Ghai*'s multi-starrer *Karma* and *Feroz Khan*'s *Janbaaz*. According to *CNN-IBN*'s Bollywood Blockbusters, "Sridevi's popularity grew so much that despite having a guest appearance in *Janbaaz*, she completely overshadowed the film's lead heroine *Dimple Kapadia*".^[68]

1987–1991: Stardom

Sridevi followed the success of *Nagina* by playing a goofy crime journalist in the science fiction film *Mr. India* (1987) opposite *Anil Kapoor*, which was described by *Rediff* as "one of the most iconic films of its time".^[69] Directed by *Shekhar Kapur*, it became one of the highest grossing hits of the year and also found a place in *Hindustan Times*' list of 'Top 10

Patriotic Films of Hindi Cinema'.^{[70][71]} While the trade famously joked that the film should have been named *Ms. India*,^[citation needed] *Rediff* also stated that "Sridevi was a complete show-stealer in the film".^[69] Sridevi's imitation of [Charlie Chaplin](#) in the film was described by *The Times of India* as "the most hilarious act she has ever done".^[72] *Rediff* also featured Sridevi in its list of 'Super 6 Comic Heroines' stating that "her mobile face expressions could give Jim Carrey sleepless nights" and that "her biggest plus point is her ability to be completely uninhibited in front of the camera".^[73]

The dance number "Hawaa Hawaai", cited by *The Times of India* as "one of the unforgettable numbers of Sridevi",^[74] also became a popular nickname for the actress.^[75] Besides comedy, Sridevi featured in the video for the song "Kaate Nahin Kat Te"; *Filmfare* described Sridevi as "truly a goddess in a blue sari".^{[76][77]} *Rediff* also featured the song in its list of 'Top 25 Sari Moments' praising Sridevi's "ability to look erotic even when she's covered from head-to-toe".^[78] For *Mr. India*, Sridevi commanded ₹1.1 million, making her the highest paid Indian actress. *Box Office India* states that with the success of *Mr. India*, Sridevi "continued her domination" over her contemporaries [Jaya Prada](#) and [Meenakshi Sheshadri](#).^[53]

1989 saw the release of the [Yash Chopra](#)'s romantic musical saga *Chandni*, with Sridevi playing the title role. The film emerged as one of the biggest blockbusters of 1989.^[79] Cited by *The Times of India* as "one of the most watched films of Indian cinema",^[80] the film also reaffirmed Sridevi's position as the top female star of the 1980s.^{[81][82]} She was also paid ₹1.5 million for the lead role.^[83] While she topped the *Hindustan Times*' list of Yash Chopra's 'Top 5 Heroines',^[84] *CNN-IBN* also ranked her first on a similar list, saying "Yash Chopra imm